

Family Guide: Supporting a Loved One with Alcohol Use Disorder

Practical guidance for families and caregivers supporting a loved one with alcohol use disorder.

Understanding Alcohol Use Disorder

A problematic pattern of alcohol use leading to significant distress or impairment, ranging from mild to severe based on the number of features present.

How to support your family member

Understand AUD as a chronic medical condition, not a moral failing or simple lack of willpower. Avoid enabling behaviors — covering up consequences, providing alcohol, making excuses — which can inadvertently perpetuate the disorder. Support treatment engagement without excessive pressure or ultimatums, which can backfire, and consider support groups for family members, such as Al-Anon. Prioritize safety, particularly around withdrawal, which can be medically dangerous.

Taking care of yourself as a caregiver

Supporting a family member through a psychiatric condition is genuinely demanding. Build your own support network, take breaks without guilt, and seek your own counselling if you're feeling overwhelmed — you can't pour from an empty cup.

When to seek urgent help

Seek emergency care for signs of alcohol withdrawal (tremor, sweating, agitation, hallucinations) in someone attempting to stop after heavy use, which can progress to seizures or delirium tremens; for severe intoxication with risk of

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unconscious); or for suicidal ideation, which has an elevated association with AUD.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

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